

films

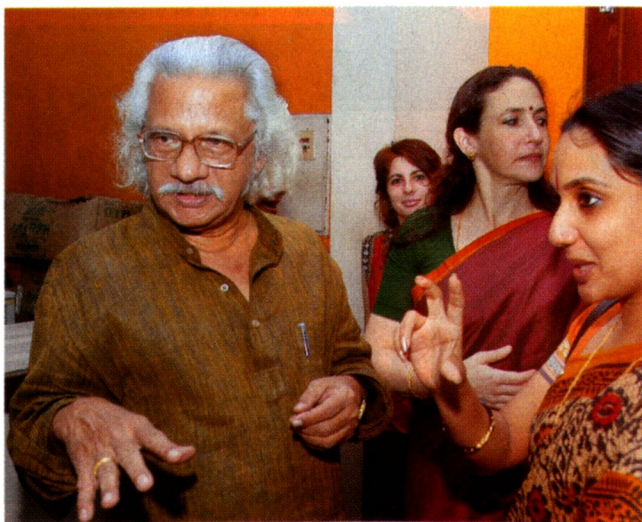
Fluid Narrative

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Celebrated filmmaker Adoor Gopalakrishnan's documentary on Kerala's classical dance form, Mohiniyattam, premiered at Locarno Festival this year. *Dance of the Enchantress*, the 73-minute film, is co-produced by Brigitte Chataignier, a French Mohiniyattam exponent with backing from the French National Centre for Cinema. The film was first screened in Thiruvananthapuram recently.

Dance of the Enchantress steers clear of conventional documentary practices like narration, voiceovers or forays into the art form's history or sociology and focuses on its sheer formal beauty. "My documentary is not to teach its history but to enable the viewer to go through the sheer experience of enjoying the art form," says Gopalakrishnan. Although he usually abhors "reality" in his documentaries on classical arts, he has weaved in the *Enchantress*'s narrative,

Gopalakrishnan (left) abhors reality in his documentaries



faint brush strokes of a storyline to juxtapose the ethereal beauty of the art form with the banal and often miserable life of its practitioners.

Cameraman M.J. Radhakrishnan ensures that the lyrical charm of the dance blends organically with specially chosen locations like Padmanabhapuram Palace, Kuthira Malika, Kalamandalam—the showpieces of Kerala's traditional architecture.

Although he has made only nine feature films in his four decades of career, Gopalakrishnan has been prolific with documentaries. "Feature film is a mission for me while documentaries provide me with daily livelihood," he says.

While *Enchantress* is the latest among his more than a dozen documentaries on classical arts, the maestro is currently giving finishing touches to his tenth feature film, *4 Women*—a trilogy based on three short stories by the late Thakazhi Sivasankara Pillai. The film is slated to premiere at this year's Toronto Festival.

by M. G. Radhakrishnan

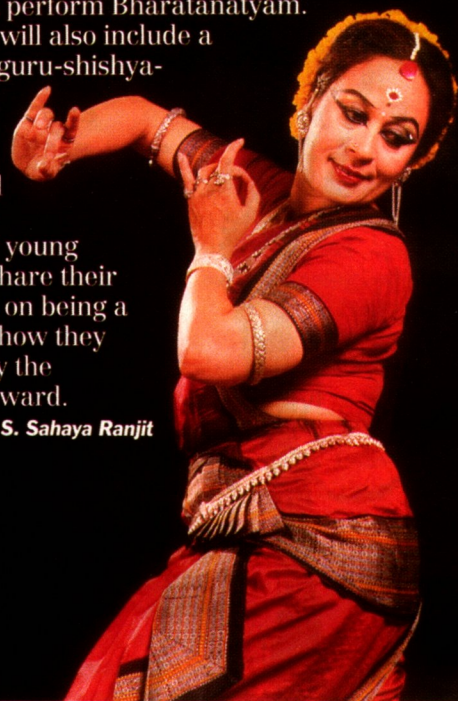
dance festival

Beauty and Grace

DELHI Gurus become legendary when their disciples branch out to continue their legacy. The same principle holds good for dancer Sonal Mansingh. Her organisation—The Centre for Indian Classical Dances (CICD), established in 1977—has played an important role in the development of art and culture in the Capital. To commemorate 30 years of CICD, Mansingh presents Pradakshina, a two-day dance festival from September 10-11. On the first day, Mansingh will present special elements from Bharatanatyam and Odissi. On the second day, her disciples Pallavi Saran Mathru and Meera Krishna will perform Bharatanatyam. The festival will also include a seminar on guru-shishya-parampara and its impact on the youth. It will be a unique platform for young dancers to share their experiences on being a dancer and how they plan to carry the tradition forward.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit

Mansingh



theatre

Historical Flame

CHENNAI *Flame of the Forest*, the latest from JustUs repertory of the Madras Players plays at the Ranga Shankara on September 8-9. It's inspired by the historical novel *Sivakamiyin Sapadham* by 'Kalki' Krishnamurthi, a freedom fighter, writer, novelist, critic and a lover of arts. The play is noted journalist and art critic Gowri Ramnarayan's fresh,



The play braids music, poetry aesthetic and humanist interpretation of the classic. The play braids together music, poetry and dance, and is set in Kanchi and Mamallapuram. At 3.30 p.m. and 7.30 p.m. every-day.

by Akhila Krishnamurthy